# Outage-Aware Reporting and Loss Recovery for Energy-Efficient River Water-Quality Telemetry over LPWANs

Kofi Sarpong Adu-Manu and Stephen Kwaku Azongo

***Abstract*—Battery-powered river water-quality nodes lose data, yet retransmission, buffering and reconstruction are analysed for short, independent losses. This paper measures loss in four real systems, two water-quality deployments and two LoRaWAN networks. Losses separate into short radio losses and rarer long delivery gaps, which hold most of the missing data in the water-quality deployments; a geometric gap-length model fits worst on every record. Replayed through a measurement-parameterised LoRaWAN and NB-IoT energy model, retransmission recovers under a fifth of the missing readings even under optimistic retry timing, at 2.3×–7.3× the energy of unconfirmed reporting on LoRaWAN, whereas buffering with back-off recovers every generated reading at an energy close to that of recovering nothing. Neither simple nor deep reconstruction keeps most day-long gaps within tolerance. Bounded event-driven batching combines hourly batches, immediate alarms, a bounded-error trigger and buffering with back-off. Tested with frozen rules on held-out data from 33 river sites, it matches per-reading reporting on alarm latency and on the real-time picture, while per-reading retransmission uses 1.34×–2.55× as much energy. Recovery of many nodes after a shared outage needs randomised probes, and large SF12 cells are limited by the gateway's acknowledgements.**

***Index Terms*—Delivery gaps, network outages, store-and-forward, ARQ, LoRaWAN, NB-IoT, energy efficiency, water-quality monitoring, data reconstruction, event detection.**

## I. Introduction

RIVER and reservoir monitoring with in-situ sensor nodes has to work where field visits are expensive and power is scarce [1], [2]. A typical node samples temperature (T), specific conductance (EC), dissolved oxygen (DO) and pH every 5–30 min and sends the readings over a cellular or low-power wide-area network (LPWAN). Such nodes lose data. The InWaterSense deployment on the Sitnica river in Kosovo missed 46.0% of its expected readings [3]; the CSIRO water-quality network in Australia averaged about 64% delivery because the gateway's connection to the server "was down occasionally" [4]; and deployment reports describe gateways that lose power every night [5], sinks that stop reconnecting until rebooted [6], [7], and outages of days to weeks [8], [9].

A node can *retransmit* a lost reading until it is acknowledged (automatic repeat request, ARQ), *buffer* it and backfill it later, or leave the server to *reconstruct* it from the site's history or its neighbours. Which response is right depends on how data are lost: retransmission helps against a short radio fade but wastes energy against a gateway that is down for a day, and reconstruction can fill ten minutes but not a week. Yet the analyses behind these remedies assume short losses: estimation over lossy links uses independent or short-memory (Markov fading) packet errors [10]–[12], and imputation methods are evaluated on random masks or simulated failures of a few hours [13]–[16]. How long real delivery gaps last, how much of the missing data they hold, and what this implies for the energy and timeliness of each remedy have not been measured for environmental telemetry.

The contribution of this paper is not a new retransmission or prediction primitive; ARQ, buffering, back-off, batching and error-bounded (dual-prediction) reporting are established. It is an evidence-to-design chain for outage-aware, energy-efficient telemetry: real delivery records measure how long losses last and where the missing data are; the records are replayed through a measurement-parameterised LPWAN energy model, with explicit bounds on what they cannot show (why a reading is missing, and when within a slot the network returned), to decide when each remedy pays; and the resulting reporting design is fixed on one year of river data and tested on a held-out year. Four research questions structure the paper:

RQ1 In the records studied, how long are the delivery gaps, how much of the missing data do long gaps hold, and is a geometric (memoryless) gap-length model adequate?

RQ2 Under these gaps, what do retransmission, buffering with back-off and batching recover, at what energy and delay, on LoRaWAN and NB-IoT?

RQ3 Can reconstruction from a site's own history or its neighbours replace delivery during a gap?

RQ4 Can one reporting scheme raise alarms as fast as per-reading reporting and keep the server's real-time picture within a stated tolerance as often, at substantially less energy than per-reading retransmission, on data not used to design it?

The contributions follow the chain.

- *Empirical loss structure* (Sec. IV). In four records, two water-quality deployments and two LoRaWAN networks, losses separate into short radio losses and rare long delivery gaps, which hold most of the missing readings in the water-quality records. A geometric gap-length model is strongly unsupported relative to the alternatives and fails worst in the long-gap tail. Where the records allow it, the cause of long gaps is traced.
- *Consequence analysis with explicit bounds* (Secs. V

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and VI). ARQ recovers under a fifth of the missing readings even under optimistic retry timing, at 2.3×–7.3× the energy of unconfirmed reporting on LoRaWAN, whereas buffering with back-off recovers every generated reading at an energy close to that of recovering nothing. The results are bracketed for the unknown cause of gaps, retry timing, storage, the duty cycle, model uncertainty and many nodes recovering at once. The evaluated reconstruction estimators, including two deep imputers, keep few day-long gaps within tolerance.

- *An outage-aware reporting design, confirmed on held-out data* (Sec. VII). Bounded event-driven batching combines hourly batches, immediate alarm uploads, a bounded-error trigger that mirrors the server's estimate, and buffering with back-off. It was developed on 30 USGS river sites in 2023 and tested, with its rules frozen, on 33 sites in 2024.

*Scope.* The two water-quality records cannot fully separate a network outage from a node that stopped producing readings, so the paper speaks of delivery gaps and treats buffering's recovery as an upper bound. Energy comes from a model parameterised by published measurements, not from hardware built for this study, and the claims are ratios between strategies on the same radio. A supplement gives the details behind each section.

Sec. II reviews related work and Sec. III the data and models; Secs. IV–VII answer RQ1–RQ4, and Sec. VIII discusses guidance and limitations.

## II. Related Work

*How sensor networks lose data.* Packet delivery in dense sensor networks varies widely between links and over time [17]. Kong et al. [13] analysed three real datasets with losses of 23–64% and named five loss patterns, from random loss to "successive loss in a row" when a node fails, without measuring durations. Deployment reports describe long gaps anecdotally: a gateway losing its server connection [4], nightly gateway power loss [5], sinks and modems that stop until reset [6], [7], and LoRaWAN outages of days to weeks [8]. Public LoRaWAN datasets now allow loss to be measured from frame counters: LoED [18] and a 16-month deployment at the University of Virginia (UVA) [19].

*Estimation and retransmission.* Kalman filtering with intermittent observations is analysed under independent arrivals [10]; remote-estimation work asks whether to retransmit a failed packet or send a fresh one under independent or Markov fading channels [11], [12], and age of information formalises timeliness [20], [21]. Application-layer coding recovers LoRaWAN frames lost to the radio [22]. None of these addresses gaps of days in which nothing gets through.

*Reconstruction.* Compressive and low-rank gathering [23]–[25] and deep spatio-temporal imputation, with graph networks [14], [15], [26], [27] or self-attention [28], [29], exploit spatial and temporal correlation. Their evaluations use random losses [16] or simulated blocks of 1–4 h [14], [15], without a per-site diel baseline, although many such signals have strong day–night cycles. River networks have a specific spatial structure along the flow [30].

TABLE I
Closest related work. Gap durations measured from data, reported without measurement, assumed in a model, or simulated; all four: ARQ, buffering, batching and reconstruction; –: not addressed.

| Work | Gap durations | Remedies compared | Energy | Held-out test |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Kong [13] | reported | reconstruction | – | – |
| Deployments [4], [6], [8], [32] | reported | buffering | – | – |
| Huang [11], [12] | assumed | retransmission | – | – |
| GRIN, SPIN [14], [15] | simulated | reconstruction | – | – |
| Arnaiz [40] | – | dual prediction | modelled | – |
| This paper | measured | all four | ratios | yes |

*Store-and-forward and energy.* Node-side buffering is established practice [4], [5], [8], [31], [32], as is gateway-side storage during backhaul outages [9]; reports also note that draining a backlog can starve live traffic [6] and that storage fails [32]. LPWAN energy rests on measured LoRaWAN [33] and NB-IoT [34], [35] profiles and models [36], [37]. Dual prediction transmits only when the server's prediction would leave a tolerance [38], [39], recently combined with adaptive sampling under an energy budget [40]; it is used to suppress reports over reliable or independently lossy links.

What is missing is a quantitative comparison of these remedies, on energy, completeness and timeliness, under measured gap processes (Table I). This paper also reuses dual prediction for a different purpose: to make an hourly batch leave early when the server's estimate would leave tolerance.

## III. Data and Models

*Terms.* A *reading* is one sampling cycle of a node: the four parameters taken at one instant, which travel together. Time is divided into *slots* at the reporting cadence, one reading per slot. A *delivery gap* is a run of slots for which no reading reached the server, whatever the cause; a *system outage* is a delivery gap verified to affect every node of a network (its gateway, backhaul or server); a *radio loss* is a frame lost while the rest of the path worked.

### A. Delivery records and the cause of gaps

The study uses four records of what a network delivered (Table II; details in Supplement Sec. S1). *InWaterSense* (Kosovo): node 1 on the Sitnica river [3], [41], reporting about every 611 s from May 2015 to January 2016. *Weija* (Ghana): 9 parameter streams of one node, October 2018 to March 2019 [2]; records marked as imputed do not count, and gap statistics use the conductivity stream (32.5-min cadence). *UVA* (USA): ten LoRaWAN sensors reporting every 5 min through three gateways, February 2024 to June 2025 [19], [42]; missing frames are found from frame counters and classed as *system* losses if no sensor reached the database in that 10-min bin, as gateway losses if all of the sensor's gateways were silent, and as radio losses otherwise. *LoED* (UK): uplinks heard by nine gateways [18], [43], of which only well-heard devices (at least 200 frames, radio loss below 20%) are used.

TABLE II
DELIVERY RECORDS. LOSS: SHARE OF EXPECTED READINGS (INWATERSENSE, WEIJA) OR FRAMES (UVA, LOED) THAT DID NOT ARRIVE. GAPS: RUNS OF MISSING SLOTS OR FRAMES. LOST IN $\geq$1 D: $S(1\,\mathrm{d})$ IN (1). WEIJA: CONDUCTIVITY STREAM (71.0%–100.0% OVER ALL 9 STREAMS). LOED: WELL-HEARD DEVICES (RADIO LOSS).

| Record | Type | Slot | Loss | Gaps | Lost in $\geq$1 d |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| InWaterSense | water quality | 611 s | 46.0% | 1,619 | 50.7% |
| Weija | water quality | 32.5 min | 15.4% | 42 | 82.9% |
| UVA | LoRaWAN, 3 GW | 5 min | 4.5% | 36,519 | 23.6% |
| LoED | LoRaWAN, 9 GW | varies | 9.6% | 56,276 | – |

Neither water-quality record has a node status log, so a gap in which the network was down cannot be told apart directly from one in which the node produced nothing. Two partial checks are possible. On Weija, the node's other streams share its logger and uplink: of the 916 missing conductivity slots, 84% were silences of the whole node, and in gaps of 6 h or more only 6% of the slots had another stream delivering. The long gaps are node-wide silences (node, logger or uplink). InWaterSense's two nodes reached the server through one gateway and one GPRS link [3]; while node 2 was operating, it was silent in 79% of node 1's missing slots, and after correcting for its own silence, gaps of 6 h or more were about 74% shared-cause (gateway, backhaul, server or shared power) and 26% specific to node 1. Most long gaps are therefore failures of the path to the server, but some may be nodes that produced nothing; Sec. V treats buffering's recovery as an upper bound.

### B. Gap-length models

A record is reduced to alternating up-runs and gaps of $k_1, \ldots, k_n$ slots; let $h(k)$ be the duration of a gap of $k$ slots. Because loss handling depends on where the missing data are, the main statistic is the share of missing slots in gaps of at least duration $L$,

$$S(L) = \frac{\sum_{i:\, h(k_i) \geq L} k_i}{\sum_{i=1}^{n} k_i}, \tag{1}$$

with bootstrap 95% confidence intervals [44]. The gap lengths are fitted by maximum likelihood with a geometric model,

$$P_{\mathrm{geo}}(k) = (1-q)\, q^{k-1}, \tag{2}$$

the gap-length distribution of any loss process with a single loss state, including independent losses and the Gilbert–Elliott channel; a two-geometric mixture,

$$P_{\mathrm{mix}}(k) = w\,(1-q_1)\, q_1^{k-1} + (1-w)\,(1-q_2)\, q_2^{k-1}, \tag{3}$$

a Markov chain with one up state and two loss states (short loss, long gap); a discrete lognormal; and a discrete power law. Models are ranked by Akaike's information criterion and tested absolutely by a bootstrap Kolmogorov–Smirnov test (Supplement Sec. S2).

### C. Energy model and loss-handling strategies

The node is a Waspmote-class host [45] with NB-IoT (the N211 module with release assistance [34]), LoRaWAN SF7 or LoRaWAN SF12 (EU868). Each transmission attempt is charged the measured energy of its radio and outcome, host time included (Supplement Sec. S3). NB-IoT energies come from UDP datagrams to an echo server [34], so a confirmed report is acknowledged by the application, end to end; a cell search without a network costs the receive power [35] times a search time swept over 2.2–60 s. LoRaWAN energies come from state-by-state current profiles [33]: at SF7 the acknowledgement arrives in the first receive window, so a confirmed success is cheaper than an unconfirmed report; at SF12 it is dearer. The acknowledgement comes from the network server. LoRaWAN 1.0.2 recommends eight transmissions of a confirmed frame with the data rate lowered every two [46]; LoRaWAN 1.0.4 sends a frame NbTrans times (1–15) at a fixed rate [47]; both are evaluated. The 1% duty cycle spaces frames [48]. A bulk frame carries 42 readings on NB-IoT, 18 at SF7 and 3 at SF12. Over a record of $D$ days, the transmission energy per day and the lifetime on a battery of energy $B$ are

$$E_{\mathrm{tx}} = \frac{1}{D}\sum_{a} e_a, \qquad Y = \frac{B}{365\,(E_{\mathrm{floor}} + E_{\mathrm{tx}})}, \tag{4}$$

where $e_a$ is the energy of attempt $a$ and $E_{\mathrm{floor}}$ the daily sleep and sensing energy. Absolute energy depends on the platform and stack: an independent measurement on another board [37] reports 3× this model's per-message energy on LoRaWAN and 40× on NB-IoT (TCP without release assistance). The results are therefore ratios between strategies on the same radio; lifetimes are illustrative.

The strategies are: *unconfirmed* (one attempt per reading); *unconfirmed + back-off* (NB-IoT; the fair baseline, because a node that searches for a cell in every slot of a gap wastes energy); *ARQ* (up to 8 transmissions on LoRaWAN, 3 on NB-IoT); *ARQ + buffer*, in which a failed reading is buffered and the node sends one small confirmed probe at a time, waiting

$$w_n = \min\left(2^n,\, K\right) \text{ slots}, \qquad K = 6 \text{ h}, \tag{5}$$

after the $n$-th failed probe and uploading the buffer in confirmed bulk frames once a probe succeeds; and *batching*, which uploads its buffer every 1 or 6 h with the same back-off.

*Replay.* A slot in which a record delivered nothing is a slot in which the first attempt fails; what happens to later attempts in that slot is not in the record. Three models bracket it: the link stays down for the whole slot (full slot, pessimistic for ARQ); it returns at a uniformly random time before the next delivered slot (restoration); or, in addition, gaps of up to an hour are radio-loss bursts through which retries usually pass (burst, optimistic for ARQ). Independent radio losses of 0.096 per attempt (LoED) can be added. The buffer is unlimited and free unless stated. Supplement Table S1 lists every input as measured, inferred or assumed.

### D. The server's real-time picture and the tolerances

Let $x(t)$ be the true reading of one parameter at slot $t$, $A(\tau)$ the set of slots whose readings have arrived by time $\tau$, and $s^*(\tau) = \max A(\tau)$. The server shows

$$\hat{x}(\tau) = \begin{cases} x(\tau), & \tau \in A(\tau), \\ x(s^*) + \Delta(\tau), & \text{otherwise}, \end{cases} \tag{6}$$

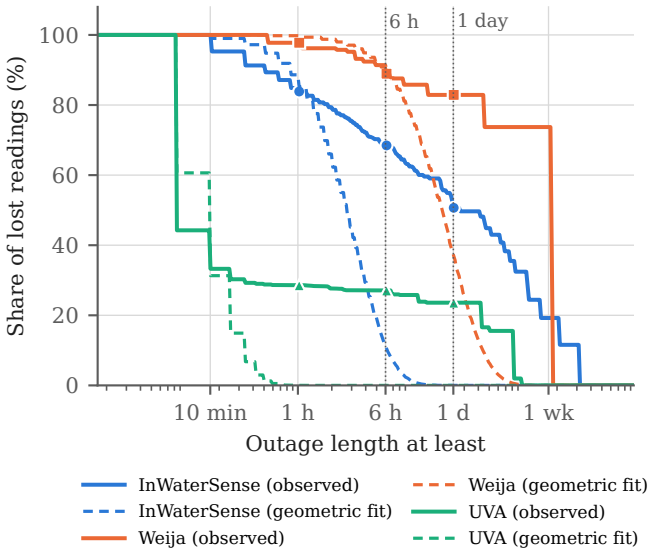



Fig. 1. Share of missing readings in gaps at least as long as the horizontal axis, $S(L)$ in (1) (solid), and as predicted by the geometric model (2) fitted to each record (dashed). InWaterSense node 1 (611-s slots), Weija conductivity (32.5-min slots) and UVA (5-min slots; radio and system losses together).

where $\Delta(\tau) = x(\tau - 24\,\mathrm{h}) - x(s^* - 24\,\mathrm{h})$ if both readings have arrived and $\Delta(\tau) = 0$ otherwise: the latest reading plus the site's own change over the same hours a day earlier (the *own-diel* estimator). The picture is scored as the share of slots with $|\hat{x}(\tau) - x(\tau)| \le \delta$. At the reference level L2, $\delta$ is 0.2 °C (T), 2% saturation (DO), 0.1 (pH) and 2% of the median (EC); L1 halves and L3 widens these. L2 lies at or inside the U.S. Geological Survey's accuracy rating "excellent" [49] for every parameter (Supplement Sec. S6).

*River data.* River signals are approved USGS instantaneous values of T, EC, DO and pH [50], with DO converted to percent saturation [51]. Sec. VI uses 9 river chains (27 sites) in 2023; Sec. VII uses every candidate site with all four parameters in complete cycles for at least half of the year: 30 of 39 in 2023 (development) and 33 in 2024 (held out).

## IV. How the Records Lose Data

*Water-quality deployments: most missing data are in long gaps.* InWaterSense node 1 had 1,619 delivery gaps (timelines in Supplement Fig. S1). Of these, 47.3% lasted a single slot but held only 4.7% of the missing readings, while 14 gaps of a day or more held 50.7% (95% CI 29.4%–64.6%) and gaps of 6 h or more 68.5% (Fig. 1); the longest lasted 13.3 days. Weija, on another continent, shows the same structure: 82.9% of the missing conductivity readings fell in gaps of a day or more (71.0%–100.0% across all streams), the longest lasting 36.7 days. With only 3 day-long gaps, its interval is wide (0.0%–93.5%), and Weija serves as qualitative support.

*The geometric model fails, and no tested model fits.* The geometric model (2) ranks last by AIC on every record (Table III), by 3,677 points on InWaterSense, 120 on Weija and 43,915 on UVA, and it fails in the quantity that matters: fitted to InWaterSense, it puts 11.4% of the missing readings in gaps of 6 h or more, against 68.5% observed, and less than 0.001% in gaps of a day or more. It is also rejected absolutely on every record ($p \le 0.005$). On the large records every model is rejected, but the geometric model's largest distance between fitted and observed distribution functions is 0.48 on InWaterSense, against 0.027 for the best alternative. No single alternative wins everywhere; the mixture (3), many short losses and a few long gaps, is the common thread. On InWaterSense, long gaps also cluster (Spearman $\rho = +0.27$ between the lengths of consecutive gaps), so all simulations replay the real records rather than a fitted model.

TABLE III
AIC of gap-length models (lower is better; best per record in bold). UVA: all missing-frame runs, 5-min slots.

| Model | InWaterSense | Weija | UVA |
|---|---|---|---|
| Geometric (memoryless) | 10,537 | 341 | 76,881 |
| Two-geometric mixture | 7,107 | 236 | **32,966** |
| Discrete lognormal | **6,859** | 222 | 33,327 |
| Discrete power law | 6,863 | **221** | 33,180 |

*LoRaWAN networks: short radio losses and rare system outages.* On LoED, well-heard devices lost 9.6% of their frames to the radio, in short bursts: of 56,276 bursts, 84% were a single frame and 99% at most five frames, and a loss after a loss had probability 0.25. UVA adds 16 months of continuous operation. The system was available 98.72% of the time; of the 58,211 missing frames, 71.6% were radio losses and 28.4% system losses, and 83% of the system down-time fell in outages of a day or more. One gateway was down for 29.9 days without causing a single gateway loss, because every sensor was also heard by a second gateway, and rain had no detectable effect on link loss (9.18% dry, 9.21% rainy; Wilcoxon [52] $p = 0.64$).

In answer to RQ1: in the four records, losses separate into short, nearly independent radio losses and rarer long delivery gaps or system outages. In the water-quality deployments, gaps of 6 h or more hold most of the missing data (68.5% on InWaterSense, 88.9% on Weija). A geometric gap-length model misses this second regime almost entirely.

## V. Retransmit or Backfill?

The InWaterSense and Weija records are replayed as the link state for NB-IoT (search times 2.2, 10, 60 s), LoRaWAN SF7 and SF12, with and without independent radio losses: 20 configurations in all. Table IV shows InWaterSense under the full-slot model; ranges are over all configurations, and further results are in Supplement Sec. S4.

### A. ARQ pays for losses it can hardly recover

Under the full-slot model ARQ delivers exactly what unconfirmed reporting delivers, at 2.59×–7.35× its energy on LoRaWAN with 8 transmissions. This is the pessimistic end of a bracket. If the link may return during a gap's last slot, retries recover 0.1–4.6 percentage points of InWaterSense's readings on LoRaWAN; if, in addition, gaps of up to an hour are radio-loss bursts, they recover 6.5–7.7 points. Against the 46 points

TABLE IV
LOSS-HANDLING STRATEGIES ON THE INWATERSENSE RECORD (FULL-SLOT MODEL, NO ADDED RADIO LOSS): TRANSMISSION ENERGY PER DAY, $E_{\mathrm{tx}}$ IN (4), PER RADIO (NB-IOT: $T_{\mathrm{search}} = 10$ S), AND THE SHARE OF READINGS DELIVERED AND DELIVERED WITHIN 1 H (LORAWAN SF7; NB-IOT FOR THE NB-IOT-ONLY STRATEGY). ARQ: LORAWAN 1.0.2 BEHAVIOUR. BACK-OFF (5) CAPPED AT 6 H. –: NOT APPLICABLE.

| | Energy (J/day) | | | Readings | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Strategy | NB-IoT | SF7 | SF12 | delivered | within 1 h |
| Unconfirmed, every reading | 229.9 | 61.6 | 147.2 | 53.9% | 53.9% |
| Unconfirmed + back-off (NB-IoT only) | 59.5 | – | – | 47.1% | 47.1% |
| ARQ (8 attempts LoRaWAN; 3 NB-IoT) | 231.5 | 447.1 | 796.1 | 53.9% | 53.9% |
| ARQ, 3 attempts (LoRaWAN) | – | 175.5 | 354.3 | 53.9% | 53.9% |
| Confirmed + buffer + back-off | 63.8 | 52.7 | 158.7 | 100.0% | 52.8% |
| Hourly batch + buffer + back-off | 23.6 | 18.9 | 89.5 | 100.0% | 52.0% |
| 6-hourly batch + buffer + back-off | 13.3 | 11.3 | 79.0 | 100.0% | 11.2% |

that unconfirmed reporting loses, ARQ thus recovers under a fifth in every model, at 2.3×–7.3× the energy of unconfirmed reporting; on Weija it recovers at most 0.9 points. NB-IoT ARQ recovers nothing, because the modem reports that there is no network. LoRaWAN 1.0.4 (eight transmissions at a fixed rate) changes the price little: 6.8× instead of 7.3× at SF7. Retransmission suits the radio regime, not the long gaps that hold most of the missing data.

### B. Buffering buys completeness at a modest energy cost

On NB-IoT, searching for a cell in every slot of a gap costs 1.20×–6.53× the energy of backing off, so the fair NB-IoT baseline backs off. Against the fair baseline, confirmed reporting with a buffer and back-off delivers every generated reading at an energy change of $-5.5\%$ to $+15.3\%$ on NB-IoT and $-14.6\%$ to $+25.6\%$ on LoRaWAN: cheaper at SF7, where a confirmed success costs less than an unconfirmed report and the node stops transmitting into gaps, and dearer at SF12. This completeness rests on three assumptions, each tested. *The reading must exist:* with up to half of the long-gap slots reassigned to a node that was off, buffering still delivers every generated reading, but only 83% of the expected readings on InWaterSense. *The buffer must hold the backlog:* the longest backlog is 22 KB; 2 KB of RAM loses 24% of the readings, 64 KB none, and writing every reading to flash [53] costs at most 0.03 J/day. *The drain must leave room for live traffic:* limited to what the duty cycle leaves after one live frame per slot, the drain still delivers everything, but at SF12 a backlog persisted for 63 days in InWaterSense's worst period, so live readings should go ahead of the backlog [6].

### C. Batching is cheaper, and costs little timeliness

Hourly batching with buffer and back-off delivers every reading, while the fair per-reading baseline uses 1.33×–3.33× as much energy; its share of readings within 1 h differs from unconfirmed reporting's by only $-3.3$ to $+7.3$ points: under long gaps the gaps, not the batch interval, decide how many readings arrive within the hour. The back-off cap trades energy against how long the server waits once the network is back: probing every slot costs 2.2× the energy of $K = 6$ h at SF7, while raising $K$ to 24 h saves only 12% more and triples the 90th-percentile wait (20 to 61 h); $K = 6$ h sits at this knee. Batching's price is the timeliness of alarms and of the real-time picture of fast parameters, which Sec. VII addresses.

### D. Many nodes, and model uncertainty

A system outage ends for every node behind the gateway at once. A discrete-event model of one EU868 gateway and up to 500 nodes (collisions with capture, eight demodulators, half-duplex gateway, gateway duty cycles; Supplement Table S2) shows two effects. Without randomisation, the deterministic back-off keeps nodes synchronised: from 50 nodes at SF7 almost none recovers within 72 h. With probes delayed randomly by up to an hour, every SF7 node recovers, the last within 42 h, at up to 12.5× the energy of a node alone. At SF12 the gateway's acknowledgements run out: its first-window sub-band reaches its 1% limit, up to 29% of received frames go unacknowledged, and after a one-day outage only 93% of 100 nodes recover within 72 h. The per-node results hold for cells of tens of nodes.

With every measured energy component multiplied by an independent factor between 1/2 and 2 (100 draws), ARQ costs more than unconfirmed reporting on LoRaWAN in 100% of the draws, and hourly batching is cheaper than the fair baseline in at least 98% of them at SF7 and on NB-IoT, but only in 85%–93% at SF12. Buffering's energy relative to the fair baseline ranges from 0.50× to 2.08×: its sign is set by the ratio of confirmed to unconfirmed energy, which only measurement on the target hardware can settle.

In answer to RQ2: ARQ recovers only the short radio losses under any timing model, and on LoRaWAN it multiplies energy. Buffering with back-off recovers every generated reading, given tens of kilobytes of storage, at an energy close to that of recovering nothing in the model, and hourly batching is the energy-efficient way to do it at SF7 and on NB-IoT. Many nodes recovering at once need randomised probes, and large SF12 cells are limited by the gateway's acknowledgements.

## VI. CAN RECONSTRUCTION REPLACE DELIVERY?

If a server could estimate missing readings well enough, it would not need them delivered. This is tested on 9 river chains, sets of USGS sites along the same river (27 sites), each pair of sites serving as target and neighbour in both orders. On a 1-h grid, gaps of 1, 3, 6, 12, 24, 48, 72 h are simulated at

the target in the last 80% of 2023. *Real-time* estimators use data up to the gap and the neighbour during it: persistence, the own-diel estimator of (6), the neighbour's scaled change (lag and slope fitted on the first 20% of the year), and own diel plus the part of the neighbour's change that its own diel pattern does not explain. *Bridging* estimators also know the value after the gap, as after a backfill: linear interpolation, and interpolation plus the neighbour's departure from its own line (equations in Supplement Sec. S5). The error on a gap is its maximum absolute error; confidence intervals resample whole chains, and pairs within them.

*In real time, a site's own diel pattern is the estimator to beat* (Table V). For day-long gaps it beats persistence in 77% of pairs for DO, and a neighbour improves on the better own-data estimator in only 30% of pairs for DO, 9% for pH and 23% for EC; temperature, with its shared weather driver, is the exception (72%). When bridging, the neighbour helps T (93% of pairs) and DO (70%), but not pH or EC.

*A naive baseline overstates the value of neighbours.* Against persistence alone a neighbour wins in 77% of DO pairs, cutting the median error from 9.07 to 5.13 %sat; but the own-diel estimator already reaches 4.33 %sat. Much of what a naive test credits to spatial correlation is the shared day–night cycle. The fitted relation also does not follow the flow: a downstream neighbour gets a positive lag about as often as an upstream one (64% vs 68% for DO), so the lag tracks shared timing rather than travel time. Evaluations of spatio-temporal reconstruction on rivers therefore need a per-site diel baseline and spatial structure from the river network [27], [30].

*No estimator keeps day-long gaps reliably within tolerance.* For 1-h gaps the better own-data estimator keeps 97% of gaps within the L2 tolerance; for 24-h gaps the best of all six keeps 31% (95% CI 18%–49%), from 9% for T to 49% for pH.

### A. Contemporary deep imputers

To test whether this is a limit of reconstruction or of simple estimators, SAITS, a self-attention imputer [28], and StemGNN, a graph neural network [26], were trained per chain on the first half of 2023, with whole-site gaps of 1–72 h among their training masks, and tested on whole-site gaps in the second half, on the same 48,455 cases as the simple estimators (protocol in Supplement Sec. S5). They keep fewer gaps within tolerance: 65% (SAITS) and 62% (StemGNN) of 1-h gaps when bridging, against 97% for interpolation, and 25% and 23% of day-long gaps, against 31%. In real time they keep 18% and 16% of day-long gaps, against 29% for own diel. They help in one place: bridging a day-long gap, SAITS's median error is 4.3 %sat for DO and 0.126 for pH, against 6.7 and 0.148 for interpolation. No estimator, simple or deep, keeps more than 55% of the day-long gaps of any parameter within tolerance.

In answer to RQ3, the evaluated estimators, simple or deep, cannot replace delivery for the day-long gaps that hold most of the missing data. Reconstruction's role is the interim estimate between deliveries, the role it plays in the design of Sec. VII.

**Algorithm 1** Bounded event-driven batching: node, one slot

append the slot's reading $x_t$ to the buffer
**if** in outage mode **then**
  **if** alarm at $t$ **or** back-off timer expired **then**
    probe; on success leave outage mode and upload the buffer
  **end if**
  **return**
**end if**
$\hat{x}(t) \leftarrow$ server's estimate (6), from readings whose arrival time is $\leq t$
**if** alarm at $t$ **or** trigger (7) **or** hour boundary **then**
  upload the buffer (newest valid reading first), confirmed bulk frames
  on failure enter outage mode, back-off (5)
**end if**

## VII. A Reporting Design and its Evaluation

Secs. IV–VI point to a design: buffer and back off through gaps, batch routine data, and show the site's own diel estimate between deliveries. Batching leaves two weaknesses, alarms and the real-time picture of fast parameters, and the design closes them with two triggers that send a batch early.

### A. The design

*Event-driven batching* buffers every reading and uploads the buffer once an hour in confirmed bulk frames. When the node's event detector raises an alarm, it uploads at once. A failed upload puts the node into outage mode, in which an alarm triggers an immediate probe outside the back-off schedule (5) (Supplement Fig. S2 illustrates the behaviour).

*Bounded event-driven batching* adds a *bounded-error trigger* (Algorithm 1). Because every upload is confirmed, the node knows which readings have reached the server and when, so it can compute the value $\hat{x}_j(t)$ that the server shows for each parameter $j$ by evaluating (6) on those readings. It uploads at once if

$$\max_j \frac{|x_j(t) - \hat{x}_j(t)|}{\delta_j} > 1, \tag{7}$$

that is, if any parameter's true reading differs from what the server shows by more than its tolerance $\delta_j$. This is the dual-prediction mechanism [38], [39] used to bound the error between batches rather than to suppress reports. Three details matter. First, the trigger is not consulted in outage mode, where the estimate may drift far and probing would waste energy on a dead link; only alarms probe. Second, the node's copy of the server must model *when* readings arrive: the duty cycle spaces the frames of a long upload, so a reading counts only after its frame's arrival, and the newest valid reading goes in the first frame. Third, the node's knowledge is only as good as its acknowledgements. On NB-IoT the confirmation is the application's reply; on LoRaWAN it comes from the network server, and forwarding to the application server, which UVA shows can fail, is not covered. A variant closes this gap by keeping the bound for both possible server states until an application acknowledgement returns in a later downlink (Sec. VII-C).

TABLE V
RECONSTRUCTION ON 9 RIVER CHAINS: MEDIAN OVER ORDERED SITE PAIRS OF THE MEDIAN MAXIMUM ABSOLUTE ERROR OVER A GAP (T IN °C, DO IN %SAT, PH IN PH UNITS, EC IN $\mu$S/CM), AND THE SHARE OF PAIRS IN WHICH THE NEIGHBOUR IMPROVES ON THE TARGET'S OWN DATA. REAL TIME: BEST NEIGHBOUR METHOD VS THE BETTER OF PERSISTENCE AND OWN DIEL. BRIDGING: INTERPOLATION + NEIGHBOUR VS INTERPOLATION.

| | | Real time | | | | Bridging | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Param. | Gap (h) | Persistence | Own diel | Best neighbour | Neighbour wins | Interpolation | Interp. + neighbour | Neighbour wins |
| T | 1 | 0.07 | 0.05 | 0.05 | 23% | 0.03 | 0.03 | 19% |
| T | 24 | 0.97 | 0.70 | 0.65 | 72% | 0.80 | 0.56 | 93% |
| DO | 1 | 0.67 | 0.49 | 0.58 | 19% | 0.26 | 0.34 | 13% |
| DO | 24 | 9.07 | 4.33 | 5.13 | 30% | 7.75 | 6.27 | 70% |
| pH | 1 | 0.000 | 0.025 | 0.018 | 7% | 0.013 | 0.013 | 9% |
| pH | 24 | 0.175 | 0.125 | 0.149 | 9% | 0.172 | 0.172 | 38% |
| EC | 1 | 0.50 | 0.50 | 0.66 | 16% | 0.25 | 0.27 | 16% |
| EC | 24 | 7.50 | 8.25 | 7.50 | 23% | 4.44 | 4.42 | 25% |

### B. Evaluation protocol

*Two phases.* The design was developed on 2023 data and tested on held-out 2024 data. In development, hypotheses H1–H4 and their decision rules were written before their runs; after H4 failed, H5–H10 were written for the bounded-error trigger before it was implemented or run. Five deviations were recorded when made (D1–D5, Supplement Sec. S6); the last, found during this revision, was a floating-point tie at the tolerance, and all development results are from a rerun with it fixed. For the held-out phase, the final design, the analysis code, its decision rules and the site-eligibility rule were frozen, and the code identified by cryptographic hashes, before any 2024 data were downloaded. The plans are kept with the code; they were not registered with a third party.

*Setting.* The evaluation uses 30 sites in 2023 and 33 in 2024 (29 in both), sampled every 5–60 min. Links: no outage, and the InWaterSense, Weija and UVA records mapped onto each site's time grid with a random offset per site (UVA as system outages plus independent radio losses). Radios: NB-IoT, LoRaWAN SF7 and SF12. Strategies: unconfirmed, ARQ + buffer, hourly batching, event-driven batching and bounded event-driven batching (L2 unless stated). Events: steps and ramps of 5 and 8 robust standard deviations, lasting 3 h, injected one at a time into the real series (7,548 in 2024); 99.7% of them stay within physically plausible ranges, and real 3-h excursions of their size occur at most sites for T, DO and EC, less often for pH. All strategies use the same causal CUSUM detector, fixed before any evaluation, which detects 58.2% of the events with a median of 0.8 false alarms per parameter per 30 days (Supplement Sec. S6).

*Metrics.* Alarm latency from event onset to arrival at the server (detected events, link up at onset); transmission energy (4), including alarm and false-alarm uploads; and the picture, the share of slots within tolerance on the series without events. Each is the median over sites per link and radio (12 combinations; 48 with the four parameters), with 95% confidence intervals from resampling sites. Table VI lists the hypotheses and verdicts.

### C. Results

*Alarms (H1, H7).* With the link up, event-driven batching raises alarms as fast as per-reading ARQ in both years (Table VII); the median latency of about an hour is the detector's own. Plain hourly batching is slower in every combination, by 0.43–0.50 h in 2024, and the bounded-error trigger does not delay alarms. Counting all injected events, the server knows of 34% within an hour with event-driven batching on the no-outage link, as with per-reading reporting, against 21% with hourly batching; the ceiling is detection, not reporting.

*Energy (H2, H6).* Alarms are rare (a median of 0.13 per node per day), so event-driven batching costs 1.00×–1.02× as much as plain batching. The bounded-error trigger adds uploads between batches, 1.05×–1.28× the energy of plain batching, and per-reading ARQ still uses 1.34×–2.55× as much energy as the bounded design (every site-resampled 95% interval above 1.28×; 2023: 1.32×–2.51×).

*Picture (H4, H5).* Plain event-driven batching fails H4 in both years, for DO only: an estimate up to an hour old leaves the tolerance between batches, and the share of slots within tolerance differs from that of per-reading reporting by $-9.0$ to $-6.9$ points. The failures occur with no outage at all; they are a property of hourly batching. (In the first development run H4 also failed for pH; those failures were the tolerance tie, not batching.) The bounded-error trigger removes the failure: its share differs from that of per-reading reporting by $-0.01$ to $+0.56$ points for every parameter, link and radio (Fig. 2), and with the link up it is within tolerance at every slot (H8, after the packing-order fix D4). The bound costs more at tighter tolerances, yet per-reading ARQ uses 1.20×–1.57× the bounded design's energy at L1 and 1.40×–3.47× at L3 (H9, H10).

*Events in a gap (H3).* Every strategy must wait for the link. Unconfirmed reporting learns of at most 7.0% of the detected events whose onset fell in a gap; the buffering strategies learn of at least 98.8%, after the gap, and the alarm probe makes the event-driven designs faster than ARQ + buffer on the water-quality records.

*Acknowledgement boundary.* If a LoRaWAN node may not trust the network server's acknowledgement and keeps the bound for both possible server states, the design costs 3% to

TABLE VI
HYPOTHESES, DECISION RULES AND VERDICTS. EACH RULE APPLIES TO THE MEDIAN SITE OF EVERY LINK–RADIO (12) OR LINK–RADIO–PARAMETER (48) COMBINATION AND PASSES ONLY IF IT HOLDS IN ALL. WRITTEN: P, BEFORE THE DEVELOPMENT RUNS; A, AFTER H4 FAILED, BEFORE THE RUNS CONCERNED. 2023: DEVELOPMENT RERUN WITH ALL DEVIATIONS FIXED; 2024: HELD OUT, JUDGED BY THE FROZEN CODE. EVENT: EVENT-DRIVEN BATCHING; BOUNDED: BOUNDED EVENT-DRIVEN BATCHING.

| | | Claim | Rule | 2023 (development) | 2024 (held out) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| H1 | P | Link up: Event raises alarms as fast as per-reading reporting | Event − ARQ+buffer alarm latency $\leq$ 1 slot | Pass, 12/12 | Pass, 12/12 |
| H2 | P | Event costs about as much as batching, much less than per-reading ARQ | Event / batch $\leq$ 1.10 and ARQ+buffer / Event $\geq$ 1.3 | Pass, 12/12 | Pass, 12/12 |
| H3 | P | Onset in a gap: buffering delivers late, unconfirmed loses | descriptive | As expected | As expected |
| H4 | P | Event's picture is as good as per-reading reporting's | Event $\geq$ ARQ+buffer − 5 pp | Fail, 38/48 | Fail, 39/48 |
| H5 | A | Bounded's picture is as good as per-reading reporting's | Bounded $\geq$ ARQ+buffer − 1 pp | Pass, 48/48 | Pass, 48/48 |
| H6 | A | Bounded costs no more than per-reading ARQ | Bounded $\leq$ ARQ+buffer energy | Pass, 12/12 | Pass, 12/12 |
| H7 | A | The trigger does not delay alarms | Bounded − Event alarm latency $\leq$ 1 slot | Pass, 12/12 | Pass, 12/12 |
| H8 | A | Newest-first packing makes the picture exact with the link up | 100% within tolerance, no outage, every site | Fail as written; pass after D4 | Pass |
| H9 | A | H5 holds at tolerances L1 and L3 | as H5 | Pass, 48/48, 48/48 | Pass, 48/48, 48/48 |
| H10 | A | H6 holds at tolerances L1 and L3 | as H6 | Pass, 12/12, 12/12 | Pass, 12/12, 12/12 |

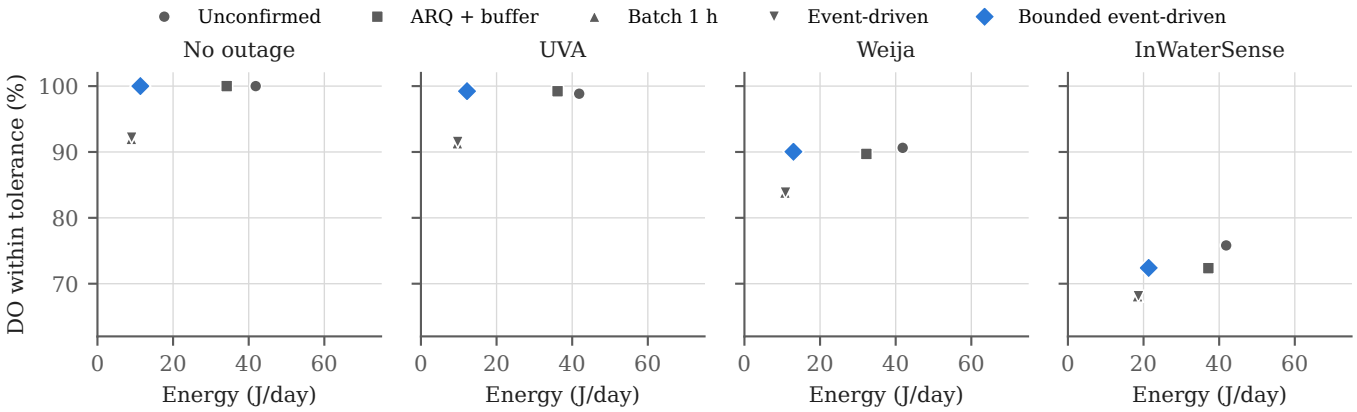



Fig. 2. Held-out year (2024): energy against the real-time picture of DO (share of slots within the L2 tolerance), LoRaWAN SF7, median over sites, one panel per link, all panels on the same vertical scale. Batch 1 h and event-driven batching nearly coincide; the bounded design reaches the picture of per-reading reporting at a fraction of its energy.

TABLE VII
HELD-OUT YEAR (2024): ALARM LATENCY WITH THE LINK UP (MEDIAN OVER SITES, H) AND TRANSMISSION ENERGY (MEDIAN OVER SITES, J/DAY); LORAWAN SF7. ARQ: ARQ + BUFFER.

| | Alarm latency (h) | | | | Energy (J/day) | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Link | ARQ | Batch | Event | Bounded | ARQ | Batch | Event | Bounded |
| No outage | 1.00 | 1.25 | 1.00 | 1.00 | 34.2 | 9.0 | 9.0 | 11.4 |
| UVA | 1.00 | 1.25 | 1.00 | 1.00 | 36.1 | 9.6 | 9.7 | 12.2 |
| Weija | 1.00 | 1.25 | 1.00 | 1.00 | 32.2 | 10.7 | 10.9 | 13.0 |
| InWaterSense | 1.00 | 1.50 | 1.00 | 1.00 | 37.1 | 18.4 | 18.7 | 21.4 |

18% more energy on the development sites; its picture stays within −0.02 points of per-reading reporting, and per-reading ARQ still uses 1.29×–2.00× as much energy.

The answer to RQ4 is yes, with the link up and on data not used to design the scheme: bounded event-driven batching delivers every generated reading, raises alarms as fast as per-reading reporting and keeps the picture within tolerance as often, while per-reading ARQ uses 1.34×–2.55× as much energy. No scheme fixes the gap itself: data and events during a gap reach the server only when the link returns.

## VIII. DISCUSSION

### A. Practical guidance

(1) *Know which regime loses your data.* Short radio losses and long delivery gaps call for different remedies. Frame counters, a log of gateway and server down-time and the node's own status are enough to tell them apart; models that assume geometric gap lengths should be checked against such a log. (2) *Do not fight long gaps with retransmissions.* Confirm, buffer and back off; on NB-IoT, back off even

without a buffer, because searching for a cell in every slot of a gap cost up to 6.53× the energy of backing off. (3) *Give the buffer room and the backlog manners.* Tens of kilobytes held the longest backlog in these records. At SF12 the duty cycle limits recovery, so live readings should go ahead of the backlog; where many nodes share a gateway, recovery probes should be randomised and backlogs acknowledged in chunks. (4) *Batch, and let the batch leave early when it matters.* Hourly batching delivers every reading for a fraction of per-reading energy at SF7 and on NB-IoT; an alarm trigger restores timeliness, and a bounded-error trigger that mirrors the server's estimate restores the real-time picture, with the tolerance as the operator's energy knob. The node must model when its data arrive and, on LoRaWAN, whether the application has them. (5) *Judge reconstruction against the site's own diel pattern*, the best simple real-time estimator for DO and pH; a test against the last value alone overstates what neighbours and models add. (6) *Engineer the gaps themselves.* No reporting scheme shortens a gap. Gateway diversity masked a month-long gateway outage at UVA, and watchdog resets bound silent gateway failures [6], [7].

### B. Validity and limitations

*Records.* The loss evidence comes from four records and supports statements about them, not a law for all deployments; Weija serves as qualitative support. The cause of a gap could be checked only partly, so buffering's recovery is an upper bound. *Energy without hardware.* No hardware was built for this study. The model rests on published measurements of specific modules, and an independent measurement on another board differs severalfold in absolute terms; the claims are therefore ratios on the same radio, tested against a factor-of-two uncertainty in every component (Sec. V-D). At SF12 the advantage of batching, and everywhere the sign of buffering's small energy premium, need hardware measurement, which is the most important next step. *Model scope.* Clock faults and storage failure are not simulated, and the multi-node model of one gateway shows mechanisms (synchronised probes, acknowledgement capacity) rather than numbers for a particular network. *Events and rivers.* Events are synthetic steps and ramps of realistic size, and the detector catches slow ramps poorly (13% of $5\sigma$ ramps); the latency comparisons concern detected events. The river data cover two years in one country, and the held-out year shares most sites with the development year (29 of 33), so it tests the design on new data rather than new rivers. *Pre-specification.* Hypotheses were written before their runs and the confirmatory code was frozen before the held-out data were downloaded, but neither was registered with a third party. Every verdict is reported, including the failures and the defect found during this revision.

### C. Conclusion

In the four records studied, data are lost in two regimes: short radio losses, and rarer long delivery gaps that, in the water-quality deployments, hold most of the missing data. Retransmission spends energy on gaps it cannot bridge, and the evaluated reconstruction estimators, simple or deep, keep most day-long gaps outside the tolerance. Buffering with back-off delivers every generated reading at an energy close to that of not recovering at all, and hourly batching makes it cheaper still. A design that batches hourly, sends alarms at once and leaves early whenever the server's estimate would leave tolerance matched per-reading reporting on alarm latency and on the real-time picture on a held-out year, while per-reading ARQ used 1.34×–2.55× as much energy. What remains is the delivery gap itself, which only network engineering can shorten. Future work includes hardware measurements, longer delivery records from tropical deployments, the energy of NB-IoT cell search without a network, and recovery across several gateways.

## Data and Code Availability

The USGS [50], InWaterSense [41], LoED [43] and UVA [42] data are public. The Weija records were provided by the deployment's operators [2]; their raw values are not redistributed, but the delivery trace derived from them (the time of every record of every stream, and whether it counts as a genuine delivery) is. The code, configurations, seeds, environment lock files, data-acquisition scripts, input checksums, the frozen confirmatory plan with the hashes of the frozen code, and the derived traces are archived at [archive DOI].

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